

LEFTOVERS

a short film

Blue Sheep Films

working draft v1.1

INT. AUNT ROSE'S KITCHEN - LATE AFTERNOON

A kitchen that fed four generations and has the scars to prove it. Every surface is covered in the wreckage of a funeral reception: casserole dishes, dessert plates, cups with an inch of cold tea, a leaning tower of tupperware.

Through the doorway, the living room empties out. Murmured goodbyes. Car doors. The house exhaling everyone.

JESS (29), black dress, heels already off, stands at the sink surveying the damage like a first responder.

TOM (27), black suit, tie in his pocket, comes in carrying six plates and the expression of a man who did not plan to be alone with her.

They look at each other. Six years of not talking stands in the kitchen with them, taking up most of it.

TOM
Everyone left.

JESS
Everyone always leaves before the dishes.

TOM
It's a skill. Uncle Marty's been perfecting it for fifty years.

Jess turns on the tap. Tests the water. And because there is a mountain of dishes and only two of them and a dead woman's kitchen to put back in order:

JESS
You dry. Towels are in the—

TOM
Second drawer. I know.

He knows. They both know this kitchen blind. That's the whole problem.

MAIN TITLE: LEFTOVERS

INT. AUNT ROSE'S KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

An assembly line assembles itself out of muscle memory: Jess washes, Tom dries, plates land in stacks. Nobody negotiated it. Their bodies remember Sunday dinners even if the rest of them isn't speaking.

TOM
Who brought the ham?

JESS
Sandra.

TOM
There's so much of it. It's a
threatening amount of ham.

JESS
You take it home, then.

TOM
I'm one guy in an apartment,
Jess. That ham would outlive me.

An almost-laugh from her. She kills it with the tap.

INT. AUNT ROSE'S KITCHEN - LATER

The tupperware. A full cupboard of it – Aunt Rose's collection, decades deep, every lid labeled in her handwriting on masking tape: LINDA. SANDRA. MARTY – RETURN. CHURCH. GOOD ONE – DO NOT LEND.

Tom holds up GOOD ONE – DO NOT LEND.

TOM
She rated the tupperware.

JESS
She rated everything.

TOM
What do you mean everything?

Jess dries her hands. Goes to the drawer under the phone – the junk drawer, THE junk drawer – and pulls out a small spiral NOTEPAD, worn soft.

She hands it over like evidence.

Tom opens it. Reads. His face does something between horror and worship.

TOM (CONT'D)
"Linda – scalloped potatoes. Dry
again. Four out of ten."

JESS
Keep going.

TOM
 "Sandra – ham. Too much ham.
 Always too much ham. Six."
 (flipping)
 "Marty – brought napkins. Not a
 dish, Marty. Zero."
 (flipping, then
 stopping dead)
 There's one for my mum.

JESS
 I know.

TOM
 "Carol – lasagna. Store-bought.
 Thinks I can't tell. I can
 always tell. Two."

It gets them both at the same time – the laugh. It starts small and it should stop but it doesn't stop, it builds, six years of pressure finding the crack, until they're both leaning on counters, wrecked, wheezing, crying a little, which was always the loophole – laughing is allowed to look like this today.

JESS
 She graded her own funeral food.
 You know that, right? Somewhere
 in that notepad she's got a page
 ready.

TOM
 (wiping his eyes)
 Four out of ten. Too much ham.

The laugh runs out the way laughs do, leaving the kitchen quieter than before. They go back to the dishes.

INT. AUNT ROSE'S KITCHEN - LATER

Casserole dishes now. The big ones. Jess scrubs at baked cheese like it's personal.

TOM
 So how's—

JESS
 Don't.

TOM
 I was going to say work.

JESS
 No you weren't.

TOM
No, I wasn't.

Scrubbing. The clock above the stove – Rose's clock, shaped like a rooster, ugly since 1988 – ticks like it's counting the silence for a fight.

TOM (CONT'D)
We're gonna have to do it at some point. There's two of us and one kitchen. It's here or the parking lot.

Jess sets the casserole dish down. Turns the tap off. Turns, finally, all the way around.

JESS
Fine. Christmas. You want to do Christmas.

TOM
Everyone always says Christmas like the Christmas was the thing. The Christmas wasn't the thing.

JESS
You called my husband a tourist. At the table. In front of–

TOM
And your husband called our whole family "a lot," Jess, which, fine, we are, but he said it like–
(stops himself)
The Christmas wasn't the thing.

JESS
Then what was the thing?

Tom folds the dish towel. Unfolds it. The tell – this family has tells the way other families have money.

TOM
When Dad was sick. March to August. Five months.
(beat)
You didn't call. Not me, not him. You sent – a card, Jess. A card with a bird on it.

The kitchen goes very still. Even the rooster clock seems to lower its voice.

JESS
You told me not to come.

TOM
I told you not to come to the
HOSPITAL. On the bad week. When
he didn't want anyone seeing—
(voice cracks; he
hates it; continues)
You were supposed to argue. You
were supposed to show up anyway.
You always showed up anyway.
That was the entire thing about
you. And the one time it was me
in the hallway—

He stops. Puts the towel down. Very neat, very final, the
way his father used to put things down.

JESS
(quiet)
I sat in the parking lot.

TOM
What?

JESS
Twice. In April. I drove there —
two and a half hours — and I sat
in the parking lot, and I
couldn't come up, because you'd
said don't come, and I'd said
fine like an idiot, and after
Christmas everything with us
needed a — permission slip. So I
sat there. And then I drove
home.

(beat)
He was my Uncle Jack, Tom. He
taught me to drive in that
parking lot. The irony's not
lost on me.

Tom stares at her. Recalibrating five years of a story he
thought he knew the shape of.

TOM
You were in the parking lot.

JESS
Row F. Both times.

TOM
(long beat)
He'd have come down. If anyone
had told him you were in row F,
he'd have come down in the gown,
dragging the pole.

JESS
I know.
(and now it's her
voice cracking)
That's why I couldn't tell
anyone.

They stand there, three feet apart in the world's fullest empty kitchen, both of them holding it the way their family holds everything – barely, and with both hands.

Tom picks the towel back up. Because the alternative is a hug and nobody in this bloodline has ever hugged mid-fight; there are laws.

TOM
Wash. You wash. I dry.

She washes. He dries. It's the same assembly line as an hour ago, and it's a completely different one.

INT. AUNT ROSE'S KITCHEN - EVENING

Nearly done. The counters visible again. The kitchen looking like Rose again – like she stepped out to the garden and will be back any second to rate what they've done. Tom nods at the wall by the pantry.

TOM
You know the rule.

On the wall, on a wooden plaque, wood-burned by some cousin in some summer: ROSE'S KITCHEN. Under it, in her marker, on masking tape, faded but legible:

NOBODY LEAVES THIS KITCHEN ANGRY. – MGMT

JESS
She added "management." She was
the only one in it.

TOM
It held up, though. Fifty years.
Not one recorded violation.

JESS
Marty and Linda, the potato
fight. '09.

TOM
They finished it in the driveway.
Technically compliant.

Jess laughs – the real one, the up-from-the-stomach one.
The family laugh. His laugh, hers, hers before it was
either of theirs.

They look at the plaque. The plaque looks back with the
full authority of management.

JESS
I don't want to do the driveway
version for another six years.
It's exhausting hating you at a
distance. There's no one to hate
up close. Everyone else is
boring.

TOM
That might be the nicest thing
you've ever said to me.

JESS
Don't ruin it.

INT. AUNT ROSE'S HOUSE - FRONT DOOR - NIGHT

The exodus. Tom, jacket on, holds a grocery bag stacked with
containers – Jess is loading him up like a supply officer.

TOM
I don't need–

JESS
Ham. Potatoes – not Linda's. And
this.

The last container: GOOD ONE – DO NOT LEND.

TOM
I can't take the good one. She'd
rise from the–

JESS
You're not taking it. It's a
lend.

TOM
The tape literally says–

JESS
 (steamrolling)
 It's a lend, which means you
 return it. That's the whole
 point of tupperware, Tom.
 Returning it means you come
 back.

Beat. Tom looks at the container. The label. Her.
 The whole treaty, disguised as leftovers.

TOM
 When?

JESS
 Sunday. I'm doing a thing at
 mine. Small. Family.
 (beat)
 Bring it back full, obviously.
 I'm not running a charity.

TOM
 What do I make?

JESS
 Whatever you want. Fair warning
 though –
 (holding up the
 notepad, HER notepad
 now, inherited, the
 torch passed)
 – I'm keeping score.

Tom grins. Steps out into the night with his arms full of
 ham and jurisprudence.

TOM
 (from the walk)
 Store-bought. I'm bringing
 store-bought. See if you can
 tell.

JESS
 (calling after)
 I can always tell!

She closes the door. Through the window, the kitchen light
 stays on a moment longer – clean counters, full cupboard,
 one container missing.

On the wall, the masking tape holds. NOBODY LEAVES THIS
 KITCHEN ANGRY. – MGMT

Compliance: total.

CUT TO BLACK.

THE END